United States was coming from the military or defense-oriented government agencies, like the Atomic Energy Commission, successor to the Manhattan Project.

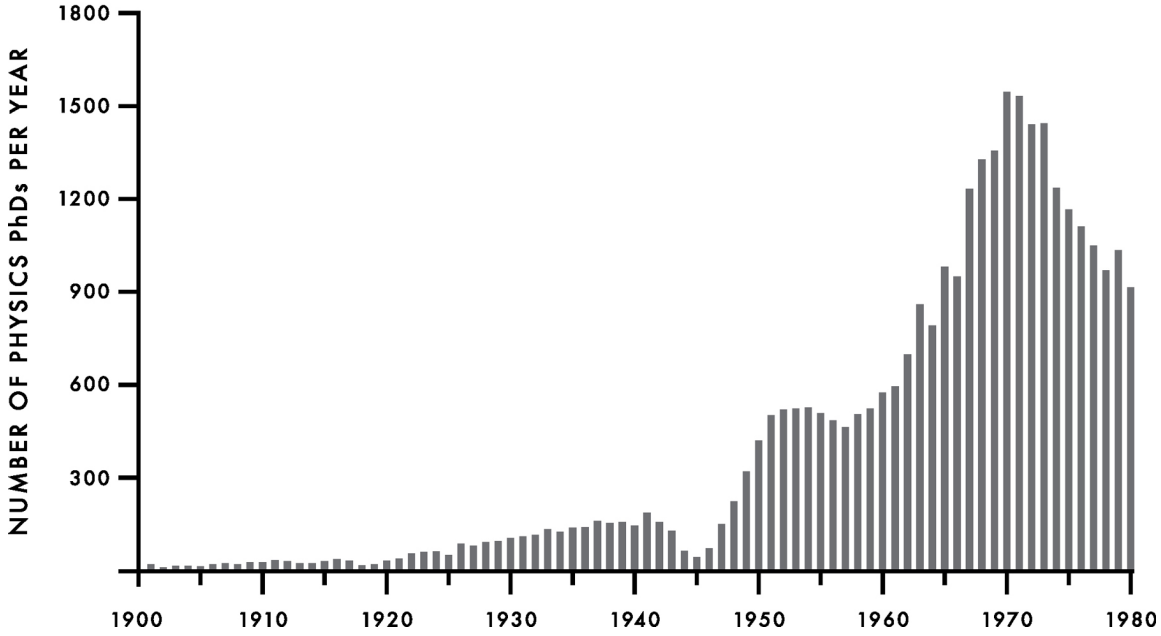


Figure 4.1. Physics PhDs granted by US institutions per year, 1900–1980.

Along with that money came people. As the war ended under the shadows of two mushroom clouds, young veterans, funded by the GI Bill, flocked to universities to learn about the new physics. “My interest in physics,” wrote a Harvard physics PhD student in 1948, “was aroused while I was working on the Atomic Bomb in New Mexico while in the Army.” Another wrote that he had a “feeling that the work [physics] was important as a result of the war”; still another wrote that “the war introduced me to the scientific life.” Physics departments were inundated with students. In 1941, about 170 US graduate students earned their PhDs in physics. By 1951, that number was over 500 and climbing, a far faster rate of growth than any other academic field over the same span of time (Figure 4.1). And by 1953, half of all physics PhDs were under the age of thirty. Educating physicists was no longer seen as a matter of mere scientific necessity but an essential investment in military infrastructure. Henry Smyth, commissioner of the Atomic Energy Commission and former chair of the Princeton Physics